Maharajas' Express

I travelled on this train from Agra to what was once the Ranthambhore 'game reserve'. One of the beauties of this luxury train is you eat your meals in a very luxurious dining room. One of the sad things about railway travels now is the ever-declining standard of food.



GETTY IMAGES

Bombay-Howrah Mail



INDIA PICTURE

I love long train journeys and that feeling of being settled in a train. Once I was travelling from Bombay to Calcutta for an important programme I was doing for the BBC on the Bombay-Howrah Mail via Allahabad. It was a wonderful journey. We arrived in Calcutta sitting in the driver's cabin of the electric train. I recall two stories from this journey. There was a lady who boarded the train in Allahabad and when we chatted with her, she said: "It's a pity you couldn't come earlier, as my husband who came to see me off is a comedian and one of his best acts is imitating different snores on express trains." Another incident was when we were belting along on the train between Dhanbad and Howrah, the electricity got cut off and the train grew slower and slower. Before it came to a complete halt, the electricity came back on and the train picked up speed and we were only 11 minutes late arriving in Calcutta, which is quite an achievement.

Jabalpur Main to Nainpur Junction

I remember another marvellous journey on a two-foot railway which was from Jabalpur Main to Nainpur Junction. It's a narrow gauge, which no longer exists. Nainpur Junction used to be Asia's largest narrow gauge railway junction. We went on the small gauge for the last time. From Nainpur, we went into the forest on those wonderful railway trollies; fortunately, this one had an engine on it. There are two sad things about all this. One, it no longer exists. Second, the Nainpur Junction's station master was very sad, because, as he said to us, "I have 23 trains a day running through this junction and they say we don't need this railway." The other sad thing was actually seeing how popular the train was with passengers who told us that this is the way they had always done it, rather than going by bus or some such. And we could see in the valley below, as we were going in the trolly, the broad gauge being brought in. It was still under construction, but this one was much, much prettier, as it was following the contours of the hills.

–with Ranee Sahaney